

AMBITIOUS VOCABULARY

Choosing precise, powerful words



1 What is it?

Ambitious Vocabulary

Ambitious vocabulary means choosing **precise, powerful words** over plain, generic ones — not necessarily longer words, but more exact ones.

plain word → precise word

2 See it in action

Plain

He walked into the room.

Ambitious

He slouched, sauntered, stumbled, or strode into the room — each word tells a different story.

Plain

She was happy.

Ambitious

She was euphoric, content, or quietly relieved — precision changes the whole meaning.



You got this!

Whenever you spot an **overused word** like "nice," "said," or "walked," ask what more precise word would capture the exact meaning or tone you want.

FUN FACT

Examiners often specifically flag the word "nice" (and similarly vague words like "good" or "walked") as words worth replacing for more precise alternatives.

3 Why writers use it

Ambitious Vocabulary helps writers: communicate a precise meaning or feeling rather than a vague, generic one, avoid repeating the same overused words throughout a piece, and demonstrate control over language and tone.

Ambitious vocabulary isn't about using the longest or most complicated word possible — it's about picking the word that most precisely captures the exact meaning or feeling intended.

4 Where you'll spot it

Exam mark schemes

Ambitious, precise vocabulary is explicitly rewarded — but **ONLY** when used accurately and naturally, not forced in for the sake of it.

Journalism & non-fiction

Skilled writers reach for the most precise word available rather than settling for the first, most obvious one.



Watch out!

A long, impressive-sounding word used incorrectly is worse than a simple word used correctly — precision matters far more than length or complexity.



Good spot!

Keep a mental (or written) list of **alternatives** for the words you reach for most often — variety prevents your writing from feeling repetitive.

5 Quick recap

Chooses precise words

Not necessarily longer words

Avoids vague, overused language



Keep going!

Try rewriting one sentence three times, replacing "said" with a more precise verb each time (whispered, snapped, murmured).